SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW:
UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS - LITTLE ROCK
TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: February 27-29, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY INSTRUCTION	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PARTNERSHIPS
BELOW	**APPROACHING**	**APPROACHING**
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering fourteen actions.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	University of Arkansas - Little Rock
LOCATION	Little Rock, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Traditional and residency elementary education programs and the special education program
PATHWAY	Traditional and Alternative
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	February 27-29, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY INSTRUCTION

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL

BELOW

CRITERION RATINGS

This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.

WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND

Reviewers examined ELEM 3301 and ELEM 4301 Integrated Language and Literacy I and II, READ 3322 Foundations of Reading, and SPED 4302 Language Development and Disorders. Use of Scarborough's Rope and the Simple View of Reading was inconsistent, and candidates lacked the content knowledge to teach with high-quality instructional materials or to evaluate and select them. No coursework in the three programs addressed concepts of print, and reviewers found no evidence of explicit fluency instruction or of writing instruction, despite a syllabus objective in ELEM 3301. Faculty emphasized vocabulary over oral language, could not articulate differences between READ 3322 and ELEM 3301, and taught comprehension only through vocabulary.

REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS

- Build and spiral scientifically based reading content across residency, traditional, and special education programs
- Have instructors label and model structured literacy components, extending practice into field experiences

CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA

Ten of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL

APPROACHING

CRITERION RATINGS

This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.

WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND

Reviewers found that the program had not yet checked whether placements were in high-performing or improving schools, though an interim placement coordinator who started in December 2023 began building those structures. The residency handbook set explicit mentor criteria, but selection differed across the residency, traditional, and special education programs, and interviewed mentors could not explain why they were chosen. Residency and traditional candidates practiced with high-quality instructional materials through ELEM 3301 and ELEM 4301, while special education candidates could finish without teaching reading. Because all literacy courses fell in one semester, candidates had no earlier literacy field teaching. Written feedback often omitted the concrete next steps that oral feedback supplied.

REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS

- Provide two-days-a-week early field placements with content-expert feedback on applying the science of reading
- Create field experiences for multilingual students and Tier 2 and Tier 3 instruction, with feedback aligned to the state evaluation rubric

CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA

Five of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PARTNERSHIPS

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL

APPROACHING

CRITERION RATINGS

This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.

WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND

Reviewers found that the program collected field experience data, problem of practice cycle data, walk-through data, course surveys, and mentor surveys, but that uneven evaluator training left the data not always accurate enough to guide improvement, and no single platform housed it. The residency program set performance gates tied to evaluation levels and growth plans, while the traditional and special education programs had no explicit checkpoints. Monthly faculty meetings run as a professional learning community used observation data, yet no formal structure monitored syllabus or instruction quality. Governance meetings with a partner district shared data and shaped professional development, though joint follow-up on affiliation agreements was absent and no written improvement plan covered all programs.

REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS

- Collect, check, and monitor accurate coursework and observation data, then use it to drive improvement
- Develop a written improvement plan with goals, benchmarks, timelines, responsible parties, and accountability
- Use the partnership personnel survey to evaluate partnerships and candidate learning with high-quality instructional materials

CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA

One of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.

CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education issues a corrective action determination. The Division selects from a standard set of corrective actions and marks each one required or recommended for the program. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the actions below are what the Division has directed the program to do.

ACTIONS IDENTIFIED	REQUIRED	RECOMMENDED
12	**10**	**2**

The Division identified 12 corrective actions for this program, 10 required and 2 recommended. Required actions must be completed. Recommended actions are directed to the program as supports for the same findings. Some actions address more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

CORRECTIVE ACTION	REVIEW AREA ADDRESSED	DESIGNATION	EVIDENCE REQUIRED
LETRS training or equivalent	RA1	**REQUIRED**	LETRS training certificates
RISE training	RA1	**REQUIRED**	RISE training certificates
Walk-through tool training	RA2	**REQUIRED**	Walk-Through tool training certificates
Course Revisions	RA1	**REQUIRED**	Revised course syllabi and observations
Cognitive Coaching Training	RA2	**REQUIRED**	Cognitive Coaching training certificates
Inclusive practices training	RA1, RA2	**REQUIRED**	Inclusive practices training certificates
Full program revision	RA1-3	**REQUIRED**	Complete program revision submitted to Educator Preparation; interim visit
Defined partnerships and collaboration with dyslexia specialists at education cooperatives	RA1	**REQUIRED**	Certificate of completion from Southeast, Great Rivers, or Crowley's Ridge cooperative
Lesson plan internalization training (TNTP)	RA1	**RECOMMENDED**	Training certificate
Identify the HQIM in all partner districts and incorporate it into revised coursework	RA1	**REQUIRED**	Matrix of partner district HQIM and its inclusion in coursework
Small group instruction training, K-2 and 3-6	RA1, RA2	**REQUIRED**	Training certificate; participation through DESE and/or cooperatives
Literacy Foundations for English Learners book study (Elsa Cardenas-Hagan)	RA1	**RECOMMENDED**	Book study notes as documentation

OVERSIGHT

Each corrective action carries an evidence requirement, shown above. The program supplies the person responsible, the timeline for completion, and how each action will be used in the program when it submits its

corrective action plan to the Division. Those execution details are not recorded in the determination and are therefore not published here.

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, University of Arkansas - Little Rock, February 27-29, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). University of Arkansas - Little Rock Science of Reading Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.